NEED TO KNOW

AYUSHMAN BHARAT AND SENIOR CITIZENS

The extension of the national PMJAY health insurance scheme to over-70 seniors could be a social security game-changer. Meanwhile, relief for depositors if your bank fails



Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

In a move that will help senior citizens across all strata access healthcare, the government has expanded the scope of the Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY) to include senior citizens aged over 70. When it was launched in 2018, the AB-PMJAY offered health insurance cover up to Rs 5 lakh to families living below the poverty line. Now, the scheme has been extended to all senior citizens and has no barrier on income they earn. The scheme continues to operate on a family approach, which means the Rs 5 lakh coverage is limited to each family.

Increasing longevity and a larger section of the population living in their 70s means the PMJAY provides financial support for families especially when they face health issues. It is well-known that healthcare is expensive, and as one gets older the complications also go up, making it difficult for families to pay for expensive treatments. The lack of treatment owing to high costs can result in the elderly suffering quietly for long periods. By expanding the beneficiaries in this scheme, the government is providing hope for those seeking healthcare.

With empaneled hospitals clearly defined, the beneficiaries can access hospitals that are close to where they live for treatment. As it is, the government has capped the expenses on procedures at hospitals empaneled to offer the PMJAY schemes benefits. How and what kind of insurance cover will be finally made available to senior citizens is something that only time will tell. Senior citizens now receive health insurance cover of up to Rs 5 lakh per year exclusively for themselves with this scheme apart from any health insurance that they may have on their own.

SENIOR CITIZENS OVER 70 WHO COULD NOT CONTINUE OR AFFORD HEALTH INSURANCE DUE TO PRE-EXISTING DISEASES CAN NOW LOOK FORWARD TO ACCESSING TREATMENT

Like all health insurance products, even in this one the beneficiaries will have the option to utilise the extensive network of authorised public and private hospitals affiliated with PMJAY. This opens treatment options at the best places and that too with the cashless option that can change the way healthcare facilities are available to the elderly. Senior citizens above age 70 who could not continue or afford health insurance on their own due to pre-existing diseases can now look forward to accessing